to return 42 acres of land to the Ramjanmabhoomi Nyas is a historic step.'[22]

This was before the Supreme Court's decision on the Ram Temple dispute on 9 November 2019, which handed the land over to a government trust that would be set up to build the temple, with equal land being given to Muslims elsewhere in Ayodhya for a mosque.[23] Modi's dramatic fronting of the Ayodhya temple's Bhoomi-pujan ceremony on 5 August 2020, presiding over it like a Hindu suratrana (literally, protector of the gods), exemplified this core focus.[24]

Chariot of Hindutva, Riding on the Wheels of Development

The BJP operates at three levels in its political communications. It has a sophisticated and differentiated messaging strategy on what issues it targets at which interest group. When it speaks to the public at large, its messaging, the data shows, is predominantly focused on four themes—anti-Congressism, the personality pull of Narendra Modi and his image as a strong leader, and finally, a wider focus on development, farmers and infrastructure.

This implies that anti-Congressism remains its biggest talking point and its biggest external strength. Until the Congress gets its act together to effectively counter the BJP, its dynastic stasis remains an electoral asset to the BJP. Its core ideological issues of toughness on terrorism, the Ram Temple, the cow and the NRC are lower down in the pecking order. The BJP does enough to assure core voters about its hard-line positioning, but in comparison, reaches out much more to others with wider messaging to draw them into its tent. The data shows that, even in the 2005–2009 period, it had started focusing on wider issues of development and on farmers much more than the core issues. However, this shift did not work then, because the Congress still had a credible leadership.

Second, when the BJP addresses its own core constituency in party communications, it focuses less heavily on the Congress. Here, too, the greater focus is on wider issues of development.

Third, this does not mean that the BJP has withdrawn from its core agenda. In fact, talk of its core agenda has consistently been on